

OVERSIGHT CULTURAL CENTER

@THEFREESTOREPROJECT
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FROM VACANT TO VITAL

Adaptive reuse of the Delancey Street Comfort Station
A community-led proposal by The Free Store Project's
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A vacant public building can become a vital community asset.



Long-abandoned NYC building. *(closed in 1956)*

Prime Lower East Side location.

Immediate opportunity for public reuse.

Collaborative stronghold for area organizations.

Acts as a central wing for existing & overflow programming, etc.

Designed to work with area Settlement Houses, Tenement Museum & various local institutions.

quality of LES Life.



The Lower East Side Cultural Center reimagines a long-abandoned public facility as a vibrant, community-led space for arts, education, and connection. Rooted in the neighborhood's history of creativity and resilience, the project transforms an underutilized structure into a welcoming hub where residents of all ages can gather, learn, and share cultural traditions. At a time of rapid change in the Lower East Side, this space offers both continuity and opportunity—preserving local identity while building toward a more inclusive future.



THE LOWER EAST SIDE



Few affordable spaces for artists, families & cultural gatherings.

Underutilized public asset.

Ongoing need for safe, accessible public restrooms.

The Lower East Side is losing space for community life.

A multi-use, community-centered space offering:

- Arts + educational programming.
- Youth and high school job training/workforce initiatives.
- Cultural events and performances.
- Publicly accessible restrooms.



● Transforming
● an
● abandoned
structure into
a thriving
cultural hub.

The Lower East Side Cultural Center proposes a clear, actionable solution to a familiar city problem: publicly owned space sitting vacant while communities lack access to affordable, meaningful places to gather. By transforming a long-abandoned Parks facility into a community-led cultural hub, this project reclaims public infrastructure for public use—creating a space where art, education, & essential services like restrooms exist side by side. It is a practical investment in both neighborhood identity & everyday quality of life.



A space where residents can:

- Create, learn, and gather.
- Preserve and share cultural history.
- Access free or low-cost programming.
- Build intergenerational connections.



**Built with
the
neighbor
hood, for
the
neighbor
hood.**

WHAT HAPPENS HERE

A FLEXIBLE, MULTI-USE CULTURAL CENTER

Core uses include:

- Coffee concession.
- Community arts workshops + studios.
- Youth + high school workforce programs.
- Rotating exhibitions, performances and film nights
- Cultural heritage archive + storytelling space



By combining arts programming with essential infrastructure like public restrooms, the project addresses both cultural and practical community needs in a single, high-impact investment.

HIGH-IMPACT, COMMUNITY-DRIVEN OUTCOMES

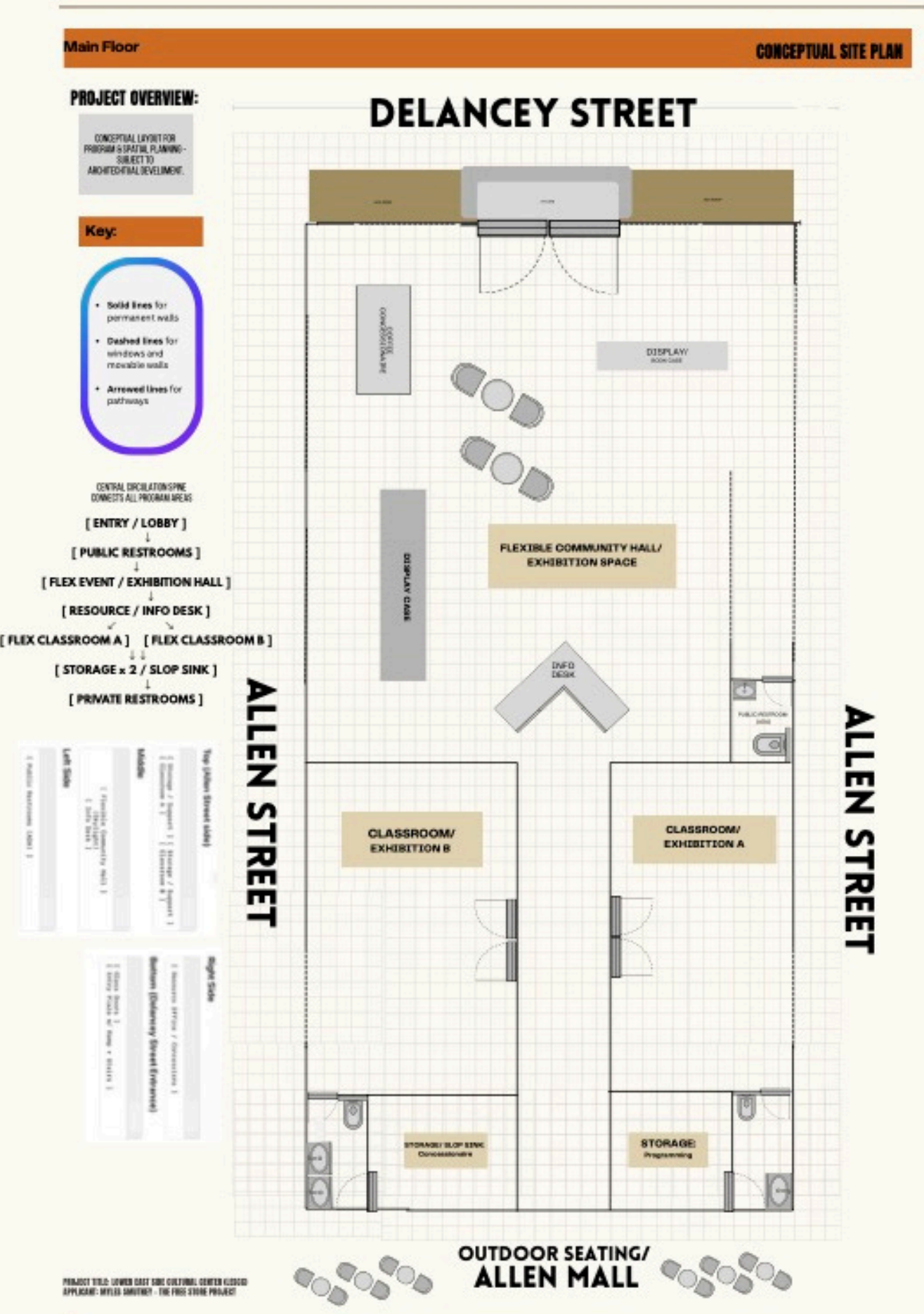
- 40%+ free programming
- Paid opportunities for local artists
- Youth engagement + after-school access
- Increased safety through consistent use

LES ... impact

This project delivers immediate and long-term public benefit by activating a dormant city asset with consistent, community-centered use. Through free and low-cost programming, local job creation, and partnerships with neighborhood organizations, the Center will expand access to cultural resources while increasing safety and vibrancy in the surrounding area.



Preservation of Lower East Side cultural history



this is unfinished public work

THIS SITE HAS BEEN WAITING FOR ACTIVATION.

- Identified for community reuse through previous efforts.
- Prior funding allocated by Parks but never realized.
- Repeatedly prioritized by Community Board 3.
- Remains vacant despite strong local demand.

At a time when New York City is grappling with how to better utilize its public assets, this project offers a high-impact, ready-to-implement model. It activates an unused building, expands access to free and low-cost cultural programming, and provides safe, maintained public restrooms—an ongoing need across the city. By combining cultural infrastructure with basic public amenities, the Center delivers outsized value: supporting local artists, engaging youth, and strengthening community safety through consistent, positive use of space.

the plan

PHASE 1: EARLY ACTIVATION + BASIC IMPROVEMENTS

- **COFFEE CONCESSION + OUTDOOR SEATING/EVENTS**

PHASE 2: EXPANDED PROGRAMMING + PARTNERSHIPS

- **COORDINATION WITH ESL HIGH SCHOOLS, TENEMENT MUSEUM + SETTLEMENT HOUSES**

PHASE 3: FULL RENOVATION + LONG-TERM SUSTAINABILITY

- **URBAN GARDENING WITH LES ECOLOGY CENTER**

TOTAL ESTIMATED RENOVATION BUDGET (\$4M)



LOWER EAST SIDE CULTURAL CENTER

MISSION

Our mission is to preserve the neighborhood's cultural heritage while providing accessible, year-round programming that supports local artists, families, youth and community elders.

OFFERING

- Multi-generational learning. Youth and intergenerational engagement.
- Weekly workshops & monthly community events/celebrations.
- Youth-centered after-school programming.
- Daily visitors- increased park activation & safety within the Allen Mall & surrounding area.

OUTCOMES

- Free programs delivered.
- Community Partnerships. Collaboration with local schools, centers & orgs.
- Job creation.
- Free and low-cost access.
- Local artists supported
- Cultural preservation

VISION

A proposed Lower East Side Cultural Center (LESCC) will transform a currently underutilized Parks Department facility into a vibrant, community-centered hub for **arts, culture, education and intergenerational connection.**

LESCC will serve as a welcoming public anchor where residents can gather, create, learn, and celebrate the diverse cultural traditions that define the Lower East Side.

Proposing a multidisciplinary cultural hub; offering arts education, community storytelling, small performances, heritage programming & low-cost creative workspace as a way to **hold onto neighborhood history & lived experience as the Lower East Side continues to change.**

DECOMMISSIONED NYC PARKS FACILITY PRESENTS A NEW OPPORTUNITY FOR YEAR-ROUND, COMMUNITY-SERVING USE.

Built with the neighborhood, for the neighborhood—placing local voices at the center of decision-making and impact. The project is backed by experienced cultural organizers and community partners with a demonstrated capacity to steward public space responsibly.

We welcome early feedback as we refine this concept in advance of a formal RFP submission.

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financial model

Revenue sources include:

- Government + foundation grants
- Individual donations
- Program fees (sliding scale)
- Space rentals + partnerships

Source	Example	Notes
FOUNDATIONS	Mellon, Ford, NY Community Trust, LMCC	Area offices of Cultural Affairs
GOVERNMENT	DCLA, DYCD, NYSCA, City Council Discretionary (\$350K)	Grants/Mayoral support/Funding already available
DONORS	Local philanthropists, LES patrons, Bronfmans	Board Members or LES institutions
REVENUE	Rentals, advanced classes, memberships	Early gifts and registry

DESIGNED FOR LONG-TERM STABILITY + GROWTH



Grounded in community, not theory

MYLES SMUTNEY
FOUNDER- THE FREE STORE PROJECT

- Built 15+ community resource sites across NYC.
- Produced 200+ hours of weekly public programming,
- Coordinated 180+ volunteers.
- Deep partnerships across LES organizations.



let's talk



The Lower East Side Cultural Center represents a practical, community-driven opportunity to reclaim public space for public good. With strong local alignment, a scalable plan, and a clear path to activation, the project is ready to move forward. I welcome the opportunity to share more and explore how this vision can be realized in partnership with the City.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how this proposal can align with broader City priorities and be advanced through the upcoming RFP process.

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